

Short talks

Most effective talks, regardless of length, follow a basic and predictable outline: opening, body and conclusion.

Use the template below, which contains tips from www.write-out-loud.com, to practise short talks and develop the techniques and phrases needed to do them off the cuff.

TIPS

- Keep your talk brief, conversational and personal.
- Select one main point to focus on.
- Pause before you start. Smile and make eye contact with the audience.

Template

Begin with the first good idea that strikes you and make it the core of your speech.

Choose the framework you wish to hang your talk on:

- Past → present → future
- Cause → effect → solution
- Point → reason → example → point ...

Jot down one main point and two or three sub-points that you would like to cover in your talk.

Opening

Lead in with an effective opening.

When I was driving here today I ... / How often do we find ourselves in a situation where ...? / I distinctly remember the first time I met (name), ..., and he turned to me and asked / said ...

State your topic and outline your agenda.

I've been asked to say a few words about ... / I'm going to tell you about ... / I am only going to mention one main point ... / We only have five minutes, so I will briefly fill you in on the one thing that everybody wants to know ...

Body

Use one of the frameworks below to develop your brief talk.

Past → present → future

First talk about what happened in the past, then lead in to what is happening at the moment and conclude by saying what will happen next.

What happened in the past

In the past we focused chiefly on ... /

Five years ago who would even have thought of ...?

What is happening now

Now we have come to the conclusion that ... /

Currently we are not only ... but also ...

What is going to happen next

In the future we will ... / The next quarter will show ... /

Time will tell ...

Cause → effect → solution

First get to the root of the issue, then state what the effects are and conclude with a solution or way out.

Cause

*The cause of / reason for / source of the problem is ... /
We are confronted with / facing ...*

Effect

*The effect / result / outcome / consequence /
upshot is ...*

Solution

The solution / answer / way out as I see it is ...

Point → reason → example → point ...

First make a point, then give a reason or reasons for it and conclude with a concrete example. Repeat this pattern for each point you make.

Point

*The point I wish to make is that ... / What I would
like to draw your attention to is ...*

Reason

*The reason for this is ... / The explanation is quite
simple really; it's ...*

Example

*Let me give you an example ... / I'll show exactly what I
mean by that now ...*

Conclusion

End with a powerful statement or, if possible, a relevant quote.

*So, before I hand over to (name), I'd like to ask you to ... /
On that note, I'd like to ... / And lastly, I leave you with this thought ... /*